

Session 18: The Golden Rule

Key Takeaways

- Jesus' teaching on prayer is linked by literary design to his command to "seek first the Kingdom of God" in Matthew 6:33. Our asking, seeking, and knocking are to be shaped by a pursuit of God's values.
- As many teachers of the Second Temple period sought to summarize the Torah, a negative counterpart to Jesus' teaching, "Do not do unto others what you would not want done to you," was well-known. Jesus' positive "Do unto others" summary opens up a limitless universe of loving and generous acts.
- Studying the Bible along the contours of its native literary design takes hard work, but putting in the effort to understand what God and the biblical authors are trying to communicate is an act of love towards them.

Ask, Seek, Knock

A
a 7 **Ask** and it will be **given** to you,
b **seek** and you will **find**,
c **knock** and it will be **opened** for you,
a' 8 for everyone who asks will receive,
b' and the one who **seeks** will **find**,
c' and to the one who **knocks** it will be **opened**.

B
a 9 Or, what person is among you
b who, when **their son** **asks** for bread,
c will he **give** him a rock?

B'
b' 10 Or, when he **asks** for a fish,
c' will he **give** him a snake?

C
a 11 So then, if you all are bad,
b but you know to **give** **good gifts** to **your children**,
a' how **much more** **your Father in the skies**,
b' he will **give** **good things** to those who **ask**.

What is the connection between [7:7-11](#) and [7:1-6](#)?

Some scholars have given up seeing any connection, assuming that Matthew simply brought together traditions that were combined in his sources.

However, if the careful attention to compositional arrangement in the sermon so far is any clue, there is deep intentionality here. If anything, like the riddle in [7:6](#) about pearls and pigs, Matthew is inviting us to meditate on the compositional arrangement and see here a deeper meaning under the surface.

In the immediate context, the preceding unit of [7:1-6](#) is all about the complexity of relationships within the community of disciples, especially when there is need for constructive criticism. One must be discerning about when to judge and when not to, when to gently rebuke and when to refrain. This all requires great wisdom and a dynamic dependence upon God’s guidance.

This seems to be how James understood the “Ask, seek, knock” sayings of Jesus.

James 1:5-7 NASB

But if any of you **lacks wisdom**, let him **ask** of God, who **gives** to all generously and without reproach, and it **will be given** to him. But he must **ask** in faith without any doubting, for the one who doubts is like the surf of the sea, driven and tossed by the wind. For that man ought not to expect that he will **receive** anything from the Lord,

James 1:17 NASB

Every good thing given and every perfect **gift** is from above, coming down from **the Father** of lights, with whom there is no variation or shifting shadow.

[Matthew 7:7-11](#) picks up the theme of confidence in God’s provision from [6:25-34](#). There, the focus was trust for basic necessities. Here, the focus is on asking God for “good things” which requires wisdom, but also basic necessities ([7:9-10, bread and fish](#)). In this way, [7:7-11](#) also links back to [6:25-34](#). The many shared key phrases from [Matthew 6:25-34](#) found in [Matthew 7:7-11](#) show there is a clear relationship.

Matthew 6:19-34	Matthew 7:1-11
Matt. 6:19-21 Prohibition: “Don’t store up treasure ... ” Inversion: Treasure on the land vs. the skies	Matt. 7:1-2 Prohibition: “Don’t judge ... ” Inversion: You judge and will be judged
Comparing Matthew 6:19-7:11. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).	

Matthew 6:19-34	Matthew 7:1-11
Matt. 6:22-23 Parable about the eye: “the eye ... your eye ... your eye ... ”	Matt. 7:3-5 Parable about the eye: “the eye ... your eye ... your eye ... ”
Matt. 6:24 Parable about incompatible loyalties; God vs. wealth	Matt. 7:6 Parable about incompatible; holy-pearls vs. dogs-pigs
Matt. 6:25-34 The heavenly Father’s care: • “anxious” repeated 6 times • “If ... how much more ... ” (6:30) • “Who among you” (6:27) • “Your heavenly father knows ... ” (6:32) • “they seek ... you should seek” (6:32-33)	Matt. 7:7-11 The heavenly Father’s care: • “ask/seek/knock” repeated 6 times • “If ... how much more ... ” (7:11) • “Who among you” (7:9) • “Your father in heaven knows ...” (7:11) • “you seek ... the one who seeks” (7:7-8)
<i>Comparing Matthew 6:19-7:11. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).</i>	

“The emphasis is not ... on the skill or even the persistence of the seeker in prayer, but on the character of kindness of the heavenly Father. ... Since it is apparent that inconsistent and flawed fathers (here hyperbolically described as ‘evil’) naturally give good gifts to their children, why would the disciples expect anything less from their good heavenly Father? Note also ... as wisdom literature this saying is not making an absolute and universal promise that no child of God will ever suffer, but is instead casting a hopeful vision that forms our understanding of God’s character.”

Pennington, Jonathan T. (2017). [The Sermon on the Mount and Human Flourishing](#). Baker Academic. 265.

Matthew 7:7-11 invites Jesus’ disciples to explore the extent of God’s generosity, trusting that whatever is good comes from God.

“For many of us, the problem is not that we are too eager to ask for the wrong things. The problem is that we are not nearly eager enough to ask for the right things. ... If he’s a father, let’s treat him as a father, not a bureaucrat or dictator who wouldn’t want to be bothered with our concerns. When he says he’s still got time, space, and love to spare for each of us, we should take him at his word.”

Wright, N. T. (2004). [Matthew for Everyone](#). Westminster John Knox Press. 72-73.

In the Lord’s Prayer, we are called to pray for the movement of the Kingdom, as well as our daily provision and well-being. If the prayer is a guide for our requests, it makes sense that we should trust God for such things.

Matt. 7:7-8: Note the increasing scale of engagement in the triad of sayings—asking, then getting up to seek, then interrupting the one we ask by knocking on their door.

- “Ask”: humility and openness, conscious of a need.
- “Seek”: links prayer to searching for God’s guidance in making a way forward.
- “Knock”: an initiating posture not waiting for everything to align, but making forward momentum.

These lines reflect the emphasis on optimistic prayer in Jesus’ teaching ([Matt. 18:19-20, 21:22](#); [John 14:13, 15:7, 16:23-24](#)) and do not speak to the reality of unanswered prayer, which is boldly the focus of the Gethsemane story where Jesus’ prayer is not answered (cf. [Matt. 26:36-46](#)).

Matthew 18:19-20 Instructor's Translation

Again, truly I tell you that if two of you on earth agree about anything they ask for, it will be done for them by my Father in heaven. For where two or three gather in my name, there am I with them.

Matthew 21:22 Instructor's Translation

If you trust God, you will receive what you ask for in prayer.

John 14:13-14 NKJV

Whatever you ask in my name, that will I do, that the Father may be glorified in the Son. If you ask me anything in my name, I will do it.

John 15:7 NASB

If you abide in me, and my words abide in you, ask whatever you wish, and it will be done for you.

John 16:23-24 NASB

In that day you will not question me about anything. Truly, truly, I say to you, if you ask the Father for anything in my name, **he will give it to you.**

Until now you have asked for nothing in my name; **ask and you will receive**, so that your joy may be made full.

Doing all this is not an interruption for God. Rather, asking/seeking/knocking is encouraged and desired by God.

- Archbishop William Temple: “When I pray, coincidences happen. When I stop praying, the coincidences stop happening.” ([Wright, 73](#))
- God is bringing the Kingdom into reality in our world like an artist, and prayer is the way some of the artist’s raw materials cooperate with the artist instead of resisting him. ([Wright, 73](#))

In [Matt. 7:9-11](#), the “father” images prompt an illustration from parenting. Jesus recognizes that even flawed human parents still have a valid sense of the good for their children. No loving parent would give what is either useless (a stone) or harmful (a snake).

The Golden Rule

¹² So then, everything you desire
that **people to do to you**,

so **also you do to them** ;
for this is the **Torah and the Prophets**.

Matthew 7:1-12. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

This famous line of moral wisdom from Jesus plays a key role in the sermon, both in its overall ethical vision for the human good life and also in the rhetorical flow and design of the entire speech.

The Golden Rule Within the Paragraph of 7:1-12

Within the immediate context of Matt. 7:1-12, Jesus is exploring the dynamics of interpersonal relationships. He calls his disciples to never “judge” others, that is, to evaluate their behavior, assuming that one knows their motives and has complete and final knowledge about the person’s character. This kind of judging can be called “condemning,” which is a potential meaning of the Greek word *krino*.

Jesus will go on in 7:3-11 to show how all human relationships require a different posture of “judgment.” One can evaluate another’s behavior from a posture of humility, assuming that I do not have complete knowledge of the person’s character or motives, nor do I have total awareness of my own motives for evaluating them in the first place!

This is why Jesus invites us to create a new default response before we approach anyone about their behavior, and that is to use the fault I see in the other as an opportunity to evaluate myself on that same issue. Only once I have done some serious soul searching should I approach another with a humble posture and a desire to help.

In 7:1-2, Jesus names the primary reason why we should never judge another person in a condemning way: The way we treat others is how we ourselves will be treated. He repeats this three times over in the b-line.

- a 7:1 **Do not judge**,
b so that you will not **be judged**,
-
- A a' 2 because with the **judgment** that you **judge**
b' you will **be judged**,
-
- a" and with the measure that you **measure**
b" it will **be measured** to you.

Matthew 7:1-12. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

Jesus often uses the passive verb to describe God’s agency or activity in the world and in human lives, and it seems that this is what he means here. However, it’s important to recognize that he doesn’t say so. This opens

the possibility that Jesus is not only talking about God as the final judge who will treat us the way we treat others, but that he could also have the reciprocity of human relationships in mind.

After the three units about interpersonal relationships that follow in 7:3-11, it is fascinating to see how 7:12 (the Golden Rule) returns to this same reciprocal theme, but in a way that highlights the human layer of this reciprocity.

A - Matthew 7:1-2

Divine Reciprocity

- Do not judge, because how you judge or measure others, “you will be judged,” and “it will be measured **to you** (ὕμιν)”

B - Matthew 7:3-11

- **7:3-4** Parable of the speck and the log in the eye
- **7:6** Riddle of the holy pearls and pig dogs
- **7:7-11** Ask, seek, knock and it will be given, found, opened

A' - Matthew 7:12

Human Reciprocity

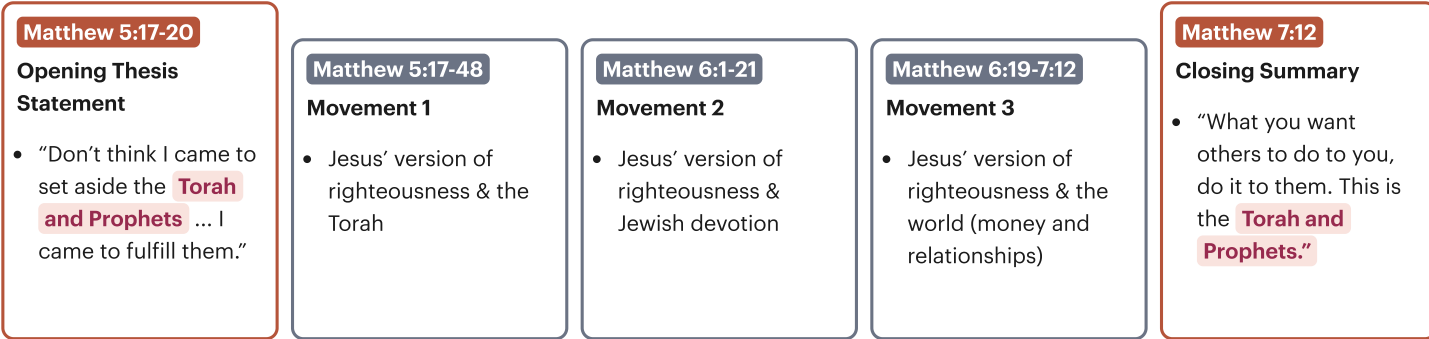
- Whatever you desire that people do **to you** (ὕμιν), do that also to them

Matthew 7:1-12 - *Rhetorical Design*. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

This rhetorical design invites the reader to see 7:1-2 and 7:12 as an inclusio structure, highlighting the mirror nature of how we treat others.

The Golden Rule Within the Sermon on the Mount

In 5:17-7:12, we transition into the heart of Jesus’ announcement. It’s marked by a clear opening thesis (5:17-20), a body with three movements (5:17-48, 6:1-21, 6:19-7:12), and the final line acts as an inclusio around the entire body:



Notice that 5:17-20 is simultaneously the introduction to all of 5:17-7:12, and also the introduction to 5:17-48.

Also, notice that 7:12 is simultaneously the conclusion of 6:19-7:12 and the conclusion of the entire body of 5:17-7:12.

When we meditate on these two bookends of the sermon, it is clear that Jesus' ethical vision in the sermon is precisely his answer to the puzzles stated in the sermon's introduction.

- What does the "greater righteousness" (that must surpass this generation of Israel's practice of the Torah) actually look like in day-to-day life and relationships?
- If one "hungers and thirsts for righteousness," what kind of moral action will result, according to Jesus?
- What does it mean for "salt" to truly "be salty" and endure in its purpose (which is enduring covenant faithfulness)?
- How exactly will Jesus' followers shine the light of their "good works" as the Isaiah-like city on the hill that will display Yahweh's honor to the nations?

In Matthew 5:21-7:11, Jesus has been exploring what his vision of "covenant faithful righteousness" looks like in relationship to the laws of the Torah (5:21-48), how it is expressed through the classic practices of pious devotion in Second Temple Judaism (6:1-21), and how such a vision reshapes one's relationship to money and to one's neighbor (6:19-7:11).

In other words, the Golden Rule within the sermon functions as a summary or epitome of the entire thrust of Jesus' argument up to this point.

"Mention of 'the law and the prophets' takes the reader back to 5:17 and thereby establishes an inclusio within which Matthew has treated the Torah (5:17-48), given rules for the Christian cult (6:1-18), and offered instruction and encouragement for life in the world (6:19-7:11). This would seem to indicate that 'whatever you wish that men would do to you, do so to them' is—in true rabbinic fashion—a general rule which is not only the quintessence of the law and the prophets but also the quintessence of the sermon on the mount and thus the quintessence of Jesus' teaching in general."

Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (2004). [*Matthew, vol. 1 \(International Critical Commentary\)*](#). T&T Clark International. 685-686.

"Within the context of the First Gospel, the Golden Rule is not a principle from which all of the law's commands can be deduced, nor is it the hermeneutical key to interpreting the law or for determining the validity of different commandments; it is instead simply the most basic or important demand of the law, a demand that in no way replaces the Torah but instead states its true end."

Allison Jr., Dale (2012). "The Configuration of the Sermon on the Mount and Its Meaning," [*Studies in Matthew: Interpretation Past and Present*](#). Baker Academic. 194, footnote 44.

The Golden Rule Within Second Temple Jewish Discussion of the Torah

Jesus was not alone in attempting to summarize the ethical vision of the covenant laws in the Torah. This was a regular practice among Jewish rabbis in the Second Temple period.

Philo of Alexandria, On the Decalogue, 18-19: "And first of all, I will speak of those [laws] which rather resemble heads/summaries of laws (κεφαλαι νομων), of which in the first place one must admire the number, as they are completed in the perfect number of the decade, which contains every variety of number ... "

Yonge, Charles Duke (1993). [*The Works of Philo: Complete and Unabridged*](#). Hendrickson Publishers. 519.

Babylonian Talmud, Berakhot 63A: "Bar Qappara gave an exposition, 'What short passage of Scripture contains the principles of the Torah? "In all your ways know him and he will direct your paths"' (Prov. 3:6)."

Neusner, Jacob (2011). [*The Babylonian Talmud: A Translation and Commentary*](#). Hendrickson Publishers. 429.

Rabbi Simelai argued

"Micah came and reduced [the laws of the Torah] to three: 'It has been told you, man, what is good, and what the Lord demands from you, (i) only to do justly and (ii) to love mercy, and (iii) to walk humbly before God' (Micah 6:8)."

"Isaiah again came and reduced them to two: 'Thus says the Lord, (i) Keep justice and (ii) do righteousness' (Isaiah. 56:1).

"Amos came and reduced them to a single one, as it is said, 'For thus says the Lord to the house of Israel. Seek Me and live.'"

"Habakkuk further came and based them on one, as it is said, 'But the righteous shall live by his faith' (Habakkuk 2:4)."

Neusner, Jacob (2011). [*The Babylonian Talmud: A Translation and Commentary*](#). Hendrickson Publishers. 121-122.

Also interesting is the question of how the Golden Rule in [Matthew 7:12](#) relates to Jesus' summary of the "most important command" in the Torah in Matthew 22.

Matthew 22:34-40 Instructor's Translation

³⁴ But when the Pharisees heard that Jesus had silenced the Sadducees, they gathered themselves together. ³⁵ One of them, a Torah-scholar, asked him a question, testing him, ³⁶ "Teacher, which is the great commandment in the Law?"

³⁷ And he said to him, "'You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart, and with all your soul, and with all your mind.' [Deut. 6:5] ³⁸ This is the great and first [*protos*] commandment, ³⁹ and the second is like it, 'You shall love your neighbor as yourself.' [Lev. 19:18] ⁴⁰ On these two commandments depend the whole Torah and the Prophets."

Jesus' second-first command from the Torah has an important relationship to the Golden Rule: You shall love your neighbor as yourself ["as you love yourself"].

"The implied 'as you love yourself' was interpreted in various ways in Second Temple Jewish literature: Aramaic Targum Pseudo-Jonathan on Lev. 19:18, 'You shall love your neighbor, so that what is hateful to you, you shall not do to him. I am the Lord.'"

Cathcart, Kevin, Maher, Michael & McNamara, Martin eds. (1994). [*Targum Neofiti 1: Leviticus and Targum Pseudo-Jonathan: Leviticus \(The Aramaic Bible\)*](#). Michael Glazier. Page.

This interpretive translation has a direct relationship to a famous teaching of Rabbi Hillel, one of the most influential rabbis in the time of Jesus (quoted in Babylonian Talmud, Shabbat 31A).

“There was another case of a gentile who came before Shammai.
He said to him, ‘Convert me on the stipulation that you teach me the entire Torah while I am standing on one foot.’ He drove him off with the building cubit that he had in his hand.
[The gentile then] came before Hillel: ‘Convert me.’
He said to him, “‘What is hateful to you, to your fellow don’t do.” That’s the entirety of the Torah; everything else is elaboration. So go, study.”

Neusner, Jacob (2011). [*The Babylonian Talmud: A Translation and Commentary*](#). Hendrickson Publishers. 127.

James (Ya’akov) the apostle made this direct connection from Jesus’ teaching:

James 2:8 Instructor's Translation

But if you fulfill the royal law as expressed in this scripture, “You shall love your neighbor as yourself,” you are doing good.

The apostle Paul also inherited from Jesus this formulation about love fulfilling the Torah.

Galatians 5:14 Instructor's Translation

For **the whole Torah is summed up** in a single commandment, “You shall love your neighbor as yourself.”

Romans 13:8–10 Instructor's Translation

Owe nothing to anyone except to love one another; for **the one who loves his neighbor has fulfilled the Torah**. For this, “You shall not commit adultery, You shall not murder, You shall not steal, You shall not covet,” and if there is any other commandment, it is summed up in this saying, “You shall love your neighbor as yourself.” Love does no wrong to a neighbor; therefore **love is the fulfillment of the Torah**.

“The saying ‘Love your neighbor’ was understood as a positive commandment, and the words ‘as yourself’ as having the negative commandment included within it. You are not to treat your neighbor with hatred, because you would not like him to treat you in that way. ... [B]y means of the parallels, we are able to see how the Golden Rule (Matt. 7:12) and the commandment to love our neighbor (Matt. 22:39) are related within Jesus’ ethical teaching.”

Flusser, David (2007). [*The Sage from Galilee: Rediscovering Jesus’ Genius*](#). Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Co. 60.

“Leviticus 19:18 generated a long history of Jewish reflection, so that the golden rule was actually a very common distillation of its message:

- Tobit 4:15: ‘And what you hate, do not do to anyone’
- Wisdom of Ben Sira 31:15: ‘Judge your neighbor’s feelings by your own, and in every matter be thoughtful’
- Letter of Aristeas, 207: ‘As you wish that no evil should befall you, but to be a partaker of all good things, so you should act on the same principle towards your subjects and offenders ... ’

- Philo, Hypothetica, quoted in Eusebius, Preparation for the Gospel, 8:7:6 (358d): 'Let no man himself do what he hates to have done to him'
- Testament of Naphtali 1:6 (Hebrew): 'None should do to his neighbor what he does not like for himself'
- 2 Enoch 61:1-2: 'And now, my children, keep your hearts from every injustice which the Lord hates. Just as a man asks for his own soul from God, so let him do to every living soul ...'
- Sextus, Sent. 89: 'As you wish your neighbours to treat you, so treat them' (so also 210b)
- Didache 1:2: 'Everything that you desire not to happen to you, so you don't do to another' / *πάντα δὲ ὅσα ἐὰν θελήσῃς μὴ γίνεσθαι σοι, καὶ σὺ ἄλλῳ μὴ ποίει* (cf. Acts 15:20, 5:1; 15:29, 5:1.)
- Avot deRabbi Natan 15: "'Let the honour of thy fellow be as dear to thee as thine own.'" How so? This teaches that even as one looks out for his own honour, so should he look out for his fellow's honour. And even as no man wishes that his honour be held in ill repute, so should he wish that the honour of his fellow shall not be held in ill repute'
- Sent. Syr. Men. 250-1: 'All that is hateful to you, you should not wish to do that to your neighbour'
- Greek and Roman parallels include Herodotus 3:142; Isocrates, Nicocles 61; and Diogenes Laertius 5:21. For a full list of parallels see Dihle (v).
- The idea of doing to others as one wishes to be done to is, it should be remembered, almost a universal sentiment. It can be found in Buddhist, Confucian, and Islamic texts (e.g. Confucius, Analects 15:23)."

Adapted from Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (2004). [*Matthew, vol. 1 \(International Critical Commentary\)*](#). T&T Clark International. 686-687.

"[In light of the many parallels to the Golden Rule in Second Temple Jewish teaching] was Jesus' formulation of the golden rule in any sense creative? In the judgment of many, while first-century Palestinian Judaism was acquainted with a negative version which prudently warned not to harm one's neighbour, Jesus himself advanced a positive version which required an absolute demonstration of love (e.g., J. Jeremias, *Theology of the NT*, p. 212). There is much room for doubt about this. ... [T]he differences between the negative and positive formulations are perhaps not as significant as has sometimes been made out (cf. Moore 2, pp. 87-8). The negative formulation does not always presuppose a calculating attitude with its own selfish ends in view: it too can be rooted in a genuine concern for one's fellows. It also bears remarking that the negative and positive versions appear in early Christian literature with little discussion of their differences. Lastly, the command to love one's neighbour as oneself (Lev. 19:18, 34; cf. Exod. 23:4-5) already implies the content of the golden rule, so the claim to find in the synoptic logion profound originality seems ill-conceived and probably stems more from Christian apologetic than from an objective examination of the texts."

Adapted from Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (2004). [*Matthew, vol. 1 \(International Critical Commentary\)*](#). T&T Clark International. 687-688.

"Didache 1:2: *Πάντα δὲ ὅσα ἐὰν θελήσῃς μὴ γίνεσθαι σοι, καὶ σὺ ἄλλῳ μὴ ποίει.*"

Strack, Hermann L. & Billerbeck, Paul (2022). [*A Commentary on the New Testament from the Talmud & Midrash*](#). Lexham Press. 514.

Babylonian Talmud Šabbat 31A: "Once a gentile came to Shammai (ca. 30 BCE); he said to him, 'Receive me as a proselyte, on condition that you teach me the whole Torah while I stand on one leg.' He thrust him away with a building measure that he had in his hand. He went to Hillel (ca. 20 BCE); he received him as a

proselyte. He said to him, 'What is unlovely to you, do not do to another; this is the whole Torah and the other (rest) is explanation; go and learn!'"

Neusner, Jacob (2011). [*The Babylonian Talmud: A Translation and Commentary*](#). Hendrickson Publishers.

"What is unlovely to yourself, do not do to him (your neighbor)."

Targum Yerušalmi, Leviticus 19:18.

"What is the teaching of wisdom? He (the one questioned by the king) said, 'If you do not want evil to happen to you, but want to experience all good, do likewise to your subjects and to those who err.'"

Τί ἐστὶ σοφίας διδαχὴ; ὁ δὲ ἕτερος ἀπεφάνητο· καθὼς οὐ βούλει σεαυτῷ τὰ κακὰ παρῆναι, μέτοχος δὲ τῶν ἀγαθῶν ὑπάρχειν πάντων, εἰ πράσσεις τοῦτο πρὸς τοὺς ὑποτεταγμένους καὶ τοὺς ἀμαρτάνοντας

Strack, Hermann L. & Billerbeck, Paul (2022). [*A Commentary on the New Testament from the Talmud & Midrash*](#). Lexham Press. 514-515.

Reflection Question

Jesus' perspective on prayer may seem idealistic and unbelievable. How do you reconcile radical claims like, "Whatever you ask in my name, that will I do" (John 14:13 NASB), with the experience of unmet prayer requests? What wisdom can Jesus' life and teaching offer?